

CREATING A FAMILY RITUAL

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Learn and demonstrate healthy communication and conflict-management skills leading to harmony within the family and cessation of addictive behavior.
2. Forgive family members' past misdeeds and begin a life of harmony with each family member.
3. Learn and use positive coping tactics and enjoyable/pleasurable activities with family members.
4. Reframe family conflict as an ordinary problem that has a solution.
5. Increase the number of positive interactions within the family.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE FAMILY CONFLICTS

- Am I Teaching My Children Addictive Patterns?
- Balancing Recovery, Family, and Work
- Communication Skills
- Identifying Conflict Themes
- Identifying Proven Problem-Solving Skills
- Is My Anger Due to Unmet Expectations?
- Learning to Ask Instead of Demand
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries
- Understanding Family History
- What Do I Want for My Children?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Parent-Child Relational Problems
- Partner Relational Conflicts

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The "Creating a Family Ritual" activity is designed for clients who experience frequent negative interactions with family members or who remain isolated/distant from their families and want to have more positive interactions. Processing of this assignment may include identifying ways that addictive behaviors have contributed to conflicts or emotional distance. It may be useful to have the client facilitate a family meeting to complete this assignment and practice other important recovery skills.

(e.g., negotiation, problem solving, communication, stress management, accountability for behavior).

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Many people in recovery have missed important events in their families' lives due to their addictive behaviors or the negative consequences of addictive lifestyles. When families are enmeshed or disconnected, conflict and misunderstanding occur more often, and resolution of either is difficult. When family members get busy they sometimes forget how important they are to each other, so family time needs to be scheduled, as any other important event would be (e.g., sports practices, support-group meetings, medical appointments). The benefits of scheduling family events are continuity, predictability, meaningfulness, and more closeness and warmth.

The purpose of this exercise is to focus on healthy ways for family members to enjoy being together, to increase stability, to communicate better, and to solve problems together. The more positive interactions that a family has, the more supported its members feel. For you, the person in recovery, this helps you stay clean and sober.

1. Review all family members' schedules for mandatory commitments. Identify possible days and times when everyone is available. Write them here.

2. Together, make a list of activities that you could share. If you pick activities that everyone likes to do, it will probably be easier to get the whole family to participate. Write them here.

3. Decide whether you will develop a ritual for the whole family (e.g., eating dinner together, going to church together) or one ritual for you and the children and another for you and your significant other. Write your thoughts here.

4. Make a final decision about what the ritual will be, schedule when you will start the ritual, who will be involved, and how often.

Activity: _____ Start date: _____

Participants: _____ Frequency: _____

Remember: make this activity a priority and commit to it. If you do, other family members will follow your lead. Also, if you have never done this, your family will need time to adjust. You may want to start with a monthly or weekly ritual. As positive experiences increase, your family will become more enthusiastic.

5. How will you deal with argument, complaints, or criticism in beginning this ritual?

6. What length of time will you practice your ritual and then check its success? (For a weekly ritual, you may want to give it more than a month before you evaluate. For less frequent family activities, you will need to allow more time.)

7. At evaluation time, what adjustments, if any, need to be made?

Be sure to bring this handout with you to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to discuss your thoughts and feelings about this exercise.